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The Charge to God

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The Charge to God

Today's Reading: John 10:16-21

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"I have other sheep that are not of this fold. I must bring them also, and they will listen to my voice. So there will be one flock, one shepherd. For this reason the Father loves me, because I lay down my life that I may take it up again. No one takes it from me, but I lay it down of my own accord. I have authority to lay it down, and I have authority to take it up again. This charge I have received from my Father."

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As the Jewish leaders listened to Jesus, they could not grasp what he was saying. He told them there would be other sheep in his sheepfold who would not be Jewish.

He was referring to Gentiles. His message of grace and forgiveness of sins would be for all people around the world—including Gentiles. Even the prophet Isaiah had said so some 600 years earlier (Isaiah 56:8). But they had missed this charge. Now Jesus has given this command to his followers.

Jesus was looking forward to the day when there would be one worldwide flock under his guidance. This flock would be his church.

From the moment the Father asked the Son to leave heaven and come to earth, his vision was for both Jew and Gentile to be united as one in the church. The Holy Spirit would give birth to it. Different people from many different cultures and ethnicities would live in love and unity in it. What a glorious vision it was!

Jesus was sent by the Father to lay down his life for his sheep. It was his choice. He wasn't coerced. He intentionally submitted himself to the Father's will. The Father's heart danced with delight when he saw Jesus' voluntary submission to his desire.

Understand this truth: Jesus not only laid down his life, but he also took it up again. His divine nature was working in his resurrection. You can't keep a perfect God down. Death cannot defeat his love. Love will always conquer the power of sin and death.

His teaching also clearly answers the often-asked question, “Who killed Jesus?” Some suggest it was the Jewish leaders. Others say it was Pontius Pilate and the Roman authorities. Others say it was because of human sin that Jesus died. All these answers are partly true.

However, a key element of the answer is this: He chose to die. He willingly laid down his life for his sheep. That was his choice. By his authority, he chose to die and then be raised from the dead.

This was the Father’s will for his life. Jesus gladly and willingly obeyed him. All this was done because of his great love for you.

Live for Jesus. Obey him as he obeyed the Father and laid down his life for you.

Go into the world and reach his sheep in different pastures. If you can’t go physically, send money. It represents you. You spent long, laborious hours earning it. When it is sent, you are being sent.

And pray fervently that people will be drawn to Jesus. Pray that the Lord of the harvest will raise up laborers to go. The harvest is plentiful, but the laborers are few.

Just make sure you are going—in one way or another. As Jesus was sent from heaven, so he sends you into the world.

It’s his great commission to all who follow him.

[from “*Hearing the Voice of God*” by Pastor David Chadwick, *Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC*]